

36 | OVERVIEW


Youth Summit on Climate Science, Medicine, & Health: A Curriculum Module

Abstract

Each summer, Harvard Chan C-CHANGE and Putney Pre-College bring high school students from around the world to Boston for a week-long Youth Summit on Climate Science, Medicine, and Health. Through workshops, field activities, and meetings with scientists, health and policy experts, and energy innovators, students learn to become climate and health leaders in their own communities.

Introduction

Young people are already living with climate change. At the 2023 summit, one 16-year-old from Southern California described extreme rainstorms that triggered mudslides, collapsed bridges, and destroyed homes. Another from Jackson, Michigan, spoke about a water crisis worsened by poverty and climate change. A student from a small New Jersey city with many immigrant and low-income families described feeling afraid to be one of the first in her community to get involved in climate work. The Youth Summit gives students like these a place to connect with others who share their concerns and to gain the knowledge and confidence to act.

How Do Scientists Study This?

The summit combines Putney Pre-College's experience designing student programs with C-CHANGE's focus on putting health and equity at the center of climate action. Over one week at the Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, students attend workshops, field-based activities, and talks with scientists, health and policy experts, academics, and energy innovators. In 2023, students were divided into seven focus groups based on their interests: climate communications and media; climate science; entrepreneurship and technology; environmental justice; global health and infectious diseases; medicine and health care; and policy and advocacy. Each group took a deep dive through speaker presentations and daily seminars. Climate content creators also joined as speakers.



FROM THE ARTICLE

Students listen to a presentation at the Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health. Photo: Harvard Chan C-CHANGE.

The Youth Summit experience



Study the Process

Bring students together

High school students from many states and countries gather in Boston for a week.

Dive into a focus

Students join focus groups from climate science to medicine to policy.

Lead at home

Students bring new knowledge and confidence back to their communities.

What Did They Discover?

The 2023 summit, the third of its kind, brought together 85 high school students from over twenty states and five countries, with more than three dozen guest speakers. Students arrived with firsthand experience of extreme weather, drought, heat, and environmental injustice. Speakers showed them unexpected connections, such as how extreme weather can disrupt vaccine distribution. Nine Climate Creators to Watch shared how they reshape the climate narrative online. A key takeaway was empowerment: one 15-year-old said she learned that at her age she has a lot of power and can make her voice heard. Harvard Chan's Vish Viswanath noted that reaching students early lays a foundation for leadership as they grow.

The 2023 Youth Summit

85

high school students attended

20+

states, plus five countries, represented

7

focus groups, from climate science to policy

Opportunities for climate leadership are fewer in high school than in college, which is why programs that reach students early can make a big difference.

Takeaways

Youth have power

High school students can learn to lead climate and health action in their communities.

Many paths

Climate work includes science, medicine, policy, media, business, and justice.

Lived experience matters

Students' own experiences with climate impacts drive their commitment.

Key Terms

Climate leadership

Taking initiative to inform, organize, and inspire others to act on climate change.

Environmental justice

The fair treatment of all people so no community bears an unfair share of environmental harm.

Focus group

A small group that explores a specific topic in depth through discussion and learning.

Advocacy

Speaking up and taking action to support a cause or policy.

Climate and health

The study and practice of protecting people's health from the effects of climate change.

Activity

Plan Your Own Mini Summit

Students design a one-day climate and health summit for their school or community.

Materials: Planning template; List of the seven focus areas from the lesson; Chart paper

1. Choose three of the seven focus areas that matter most to your community.
2. For each area, plan one activity, such as a guest speaker, a field visit, or a workshop.
3. Identify local experts you could invite, such as a nurse, a city planner, or a scientist.
4. Write a short invitation explaining why students should attend.
5. Share your plan and choose one action from it that your class could actually carry out.

References

Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, C-CHANGE. Youth Summit on Climate Science, Medicine, & Health.
<https://hsph.harvard.edu/research/climate-health-c-change/education/youth-summit-on-climate-equity-and-health/>

Staff Writer (2023). Youth Climate Summit Brings Together High School Students from Across the Globe. Harvard Chan C-CHANGE. <https://hsph.harvard.edu/climate-health-c-change/news/2023youthsummit/>